Interviewer guide: Years 1 and 2

This guide is reusable. Nothing is written on it: keep one in the room, in a folder or laminated. Ratings and notes for each child go on the **Interview sheet** (`forms/Interview_Sheet_Y1_Y2`).

About 6 minutes, 1:1, play-based. Most of what you need about a 5 or 6 year old comes from watching them during the whole visit, not from questions. This short chat, at the end of the visit, is **in English**. It has three jobs: to hear the child's spoken English, to get to know the child (likes, family, friends, **what they want to be**), and to judge their readiness for the international programme. Use the list in Section 3 for the whole visit, and tick it on the Interview sheet. The sentence reading is not part of this chat: in Years 1 to 3 the assessor runs the Graded Sentence Reading Screen (`shared/Sentence_Reading_Guide`) after the Early Reading Screen and writes the points on the Reading front sheet.

How to do it. Sit on the floor or at a low table beside the child. Offer paper and crayons: "Can you draw you, doing something you love?" Talk about the drawing. Ask the main question first; if the child does not answer, use the **easier** prompt (a choice, a yes or no, or "show me"). Wait. Praise effort. Never press a child who is upset; stop and let them go back to their parent.

Pace of speech. Speak slowly and clearly, about 120 words a minute: short phrases, with a pause after each. Use the same pace for every candidate in the year group. Do not rush: wait at least five seconds before rephrasing.

Safeguarding. A young child is never alone with one adult behind a closed door. If a child says something that worries you, write down their words and pass it to the Designated Safeguarding Lead the same day.

1. Questions

On the Interview sheet, write short notes under "Key things the student said" (their own words, and how they said it), and a line about the drawing.

Topic	Main question	Easier
Me	What is your name? How old are you?	Show me with your fingers.
	Tell me about your picture.	Is this you? What are you doing?
Family	Who lives at your home?	Do you have a brother? A sister? A pet?
Likes	What do you like to play?	Do you like to run? Draw? Play with blocks?
	What is your favourite food? Favourite animal?	Do you like noodles? Do you like cats?
School	Tell me about your school (or kindergarten).	Do you like it? What do you do there?
	Who are your friends?	Do you play with friends?
Feelings	What makes you happy?	Are you happy today? (point to a happy or sad face)
When I grow up	What do you want to be when you grow up?	A teacher? A doctor? A footballer?
Here	Would you like to come to this school? What would you like to do here?	Do you want to play here? Learn English here?

2. Speaking band

Choose the band that fits best, for a child of this age, and tick it on the Interview sheet. Rate **listening in conversation** with the same letters.

Band	What you hear
A New to English	No English yet, or one or two words. Uses Chinese, pointing or silence. May copy a word you say.
B Early acquisition	Single words and short phrases ("cat", "my mummy", "I like red"). Understands simple questions with gesture or pictures.
C Developing competence	Short sentences about familiar things ("I play with my friend"), with errors. Understands most simple questions.
D Competent	Talks in sentences, tells you about the picture or a simple event, joins ideas with "and" or "because".
E Fluent	Talks as a fluent English-speaking child of 5 or 6 would.

3. What to look for during the whole visit

Tick what you saw on the Interview sheet, and add a note.

- Separates from the parent without great distress, or settles within a few minutes
- Joins in the activities and stays with each one for a few minutes
- Follows a simple instruction (with gesture if needed)
- Holds a pencil or crayon with control; draws a person with several parts
- Takes turns, shares, waits
- Shows curiosity: looks, touches, asks, explores
- Copies new English words, or tries to
- Recovers when something is hard or when they do not understand
- Uses the toilet, coat and shoes independently (ask the parent)

4. Readiness

Rate each strand on the Interview sheet: **1** Concern, **2** Some concern, **3** Good, **4** Strong. Write the evidence: a short quotation or what you saw.

Strand	What strong looks like at this age
Attitude to learning	Enjoys the activities, has a go, pleased with success
Curiosity and engagement	Interested, explores, asks questions
Social and emotional readiness	Settles with new adults, manages separation, plays alongside or with others
Independence	Manages simple tasks and self-care for age
Kindness and conduct	Gentle, polite, shares
Readiness for learning in English	Happy in an English-speaking setting, tries words, is not distressed by not understanding

5. Anything to follow up

Tick any that apply on the Interview sheet, and add a note:

- Speech and language (for example very little speech in Chinese as well as English, unclear speech for age)
- Attention, hearing, vision, movement or fine motor skills
- Wellbeing (for example very anxious, very tired)
- Safeguarding (passed to the Designated Safeguarding Lead the same day)
- Medical or dietary

Speech in Chinese. Ask the parent how the child speaks in Chinese (Parent Conversation Record, Section 4). A child with little English but age-appropriate Chinese is a typical English learner. A child who also has very little speech in Chinese for their age may need a speech and language check: raise it with the parent gently, as a question rather than a conclusion.

Receiving homeroom teacher (optional). If the likely homeroom teacher meets the child, they note first impressions and what the child would need in the first weeks (for example a buddy, picture cards for routines, a familiar comfort object, a gradual start) on the Interview sheet.

To finish. On the Interview sheet, write your comment for the final mark sheet (strengths, concerns, support), and sign and date it.